

C&E BRANCH COLONEL COMMANDANT

REFERENCES:

- A. CFAO 3-4
- B. CAO 11-09
- C. AFO 5002-0
- D. CDS Letter dated 30 July 2016 – CAF HONORARY APPOINTMENTS PROGRAM – MND'S APPRECIATION AND VISION: GENDER PARITY
- E. COS IM Letter dated 6 October 2017 – DIVERSITY AND GENDER PARITY ASSISTANT DEPUTY MINISTER INFORMATION MANAGEMENT HONORARY APPOINTMENTS

ORIGINS

The appointment of Colonels-Commandant is a centuries-old tradition that Branches of the Canadian Forces have chosen to inherit from the British Army. The appointment of Colonel-Commandant evolved similar to that of Colonel of the Regiment, in the British Army and subsequently the Canadian Army, generally in corps/regiments/branches which had originated as "families" of tactical units.

The exact origin of this appointment is somewhat vague but has been traced as an honorary appointment in 1722 to the Royal Artillery. When the title was first adopted by the British infantry in 1756 with the 2nd Green Jackets, the King's Rifle Corps, it was a commanding officer's position. Their Colonel-Commandant commanded each of that Regiment's four battalions until 1759. From 1921 to 1928, Colonel-Commandant along with "Colonel of the Staff" became an official rank. The two replaced Brigadier in the British Army for that period.

CANADIAN COLONEL COMMANDANT APPOINTMENTS

As an honorary appointment, the first Colonel-Commandant in the Canadian Army was appointed for the Royal Canadian Artillery in January 1925. In December 1947, each corps of the Canadian Army was permitted to have its own Colonel-Commandant. Our first Royal Canadian Signals Colonel Commandant was Brigadier J.E. Genet, CBE, MC, CD, who was appointed to that position on 18 August 1948. At unification, Lt Gen S.F. Clark, CBE, CD became the first Colonel Commandant of the C&E Branch.

Canadian Forces Administrative Orders were eventually promulgated, which indicated that a Colonel-Commandant could be appointed for any branch of the CAF, with the Chaplain Branch permitted two, one for Chaplain (P) and one for Chaplain (RC) (i.e. one Protestant and one Roman Catholic) as well as one for the Royal Canadian Army Cadets. An appointment as Colonel-Commandant is restricted to former officers of the Canadian Armed Forces who, normally, held the rank of Colonel or above on retirement. Recommendations could be initiated only by the Branch Advisor of a Branch, or by the Director General Reserves and Cadets (DGRC) and only for the Royal Canadian Army Cadets. Nominations are subject to the approval of the Minister of National Defence.

NOMINATIONS AND SELECTION

C&E Branch Nomination and Selection is as follows:

- A list of all former C&E General Officers and Colonels is maintained and updated by the Branch Office;
- Succession Planning for the Colonel Commandant is initiated in the second year of the Colonel Commandant's Term and starts with a short list of potential nominees generated between the Colonel Commandant and Branch Leader. Appropriate attention will be paid to References D and E – CDS's and former COS IM's guidance related to diversity and gender parity in the identification of potential nominees;
- The Colonel Commandant then undertakes to confirm interest and willingness on behalf of the potential nominees and makes recommendations to the Branch Leader as appropriate.
- A Selection Committee comprising the Branch Leader, Colonel Commandant, Branch Advisor and Branch CWO will select a nominee from the short-listed candidates and subject to the prospective nominee's agreement to submit his/her name, will seek endorsement by the C&E Senate. If endorsed, the Branch Advisor will prepare the appropriate nomination package for CDS and MND Approval.
- The official change of appointment ceremony is generally held in conjunction with another significant C&E Family activity when representatives from across the country are gathered together. The ceremony is normally held in conjunction with a parade.

C&E BRANCH COLONEL COMMANDANT DUTIES

A Colonel Commandant is not involved in the operational affairs of the units of the Branch. The Colonel Commandant is considered a 'conscience keeper' of the Branch and a guardian of its traditions – a link between the past and the present. The Colonel Commandant represents all members of the C&E Branch including serving members – Regular and Reserve, retired members and their families. Specific duties include:

1. Fosters esprit de corps throughout the C&E Branch including the RCCS, RCAF, RCN elements of the Branch.
2. Fosters the unity of the C&E Family – Regular & Reserve (Serving & Retired), Honorary appointments & Industry Partners and Friends of the C&E Branch.
3. Provides a channel of communications between the Branch and the Colonel-in-Chief, including informing the Colonel-in-Chief of significant C&E activities and coordinating visits with HRH through her Private Secretary.
4. Represents the C&E Family at ceremonial events, funerals, and C&E and home station events.
5. Selecting persons to attend memorial activities under Department of Veterans Affairs sponsorship.
6. Co-Chairs with the Branch Leader the C&E Senate;
7. Advises CDS and Canadian Armed Forces Military Leaders in his/her capacity as Colonel Commandant.
8. Advises the C&E Branch Leader and Branch Advisor on:
 - a. Matters of significance to the Branch and broader C&E family
 - b. Heritage programs and events, as appropriate

- c. Dress, Customs, history and traditions
 - d. Management of Branch Fund
- 9. Advises the Branch Advisor, Director of Signals, RCAF CELE Colonel, Commander CFIOG, and C&E Association on all matters of significance to the Branch.
- 10. Maintains a dialogue with all Honorary appointments appointed to C&E units;
- 11. Visits and Maintains dialogue with:
 - a. Units of the Regular Force and Reserve Force within the Branch;
 - b. Cadet units associated with the Branch and RCCS; and
 - c. Allied Corps or affiliated formations, regiments and units.
- 12. Liaises with professional C&E related associations to foster interest among civilian industry regarding military aspects of the profession.
- 13. Attends the Conference of Defence Association meetings as an observer along with the other C&E Family representative – President C&E Association.

PAST AND PRESENT COLONELS COMMANDANT

THE ROYAL CANADIAN CORPS OF SIGNALS

- | | |
|--|----------------------------------|
| 1. Brigadier JE Genet, CBE, MC, CD | 18 August 1948-18 August 1954 |
| 2. Brigadier A.W. Beament, CBE, VD, CD | 19 August 1954-19 September 1962 |
| 3. Brigadier C.S. McKee, CBE, VD, CD | 20 September 1962-23 March 1966 |
| 4. Lt Gen S.F. Clark, CBE, CD | 24 March 1966-23 March 1973 |

THE COMMUNICATIONS AND ELECTRONICS BRANCH

- | | |
|---|----------------------------------|
| 1. Lt Gen S.F. Clark, CBE, CD | 24 March 1966-23 March 1973 |
| 2. Brigadier-General J.B. Clement, CD | 24 March 1973-31 December 1976 |
| 3. Brigadier-General R.E. Mooney, CMM, CD | 1 January 1977-31 December 1980 |
| 4. Major General L.H. Wylie, CD | 1 January 1981-31 December 1983 |
| 5. Brigadier-General J.D. Richards, OMM, CD | 1 January 1984-31 December 1986 |
| 6. Brigadier-General H.F. Webber, CD | 1 January 1987-22 October 1989 |
| 7. Major General R.N. Senior, CMM, CD | 24 November 1989-22 October 1992 |
| 8. Colonel P.E. Morneault, CD | 23 October 1992-25 October 1996 |
| 9. Captain (N) J.E. Croft, CD | 26 October 1996-21 February 2000 |
| 10. Brigadier-General D. Banks, CMM, CD | 22 February 2000-16 January 2004 |
| 11. Brigadier-General R.P. Fraser, OMM, CD | 17 January 2004-11 December 2006 |
| 12. Colonel G. Lackonik, CD | 12 December 2006- 19 May 2011 |
| 13. Brigadier-General J.J.M. Charron, OMM, CD | 20 May 2011-24 October 2014 |
| 14. Brigadier-General W.S. Richard, CD | 24 October 2014 - 22 May 2018 |
| 15. Brigadier-General K.G. O'Keefe, OMM, CD | 22 May 2018-Present |